

GIRLS BASKETBALL:
DIVISION I DISTRICTFouls
fellLack of depth
dooms Bulldogs
after early callsSteve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

PARMA HEIGHTS — The public address system at Valley Forge High School was malfunctioning during Saturday afternoon's Division I district championship game.

There were no such glitches in the referees' whistles. Those were working just fine.

The officials called 12 fouls in the first quarter — eight against Olmsted Falls. That certainly didn't bode well for the Bulldogs, for whom depth isn't a strength.

"It took some of the aggressiveness away from our kids," coach Matt Fulton said after the Bulldogs fell to Solon, 52-37, in their first visit to a district title game since 1999.

"I would never blame the officiating for a loss, but they were calling a close game," Fulton said. "We didn't adjust to how the game was going."

The whistles got less of a workout in the succeeding quarters, but the Bulldogs fell to Solon, 52-37, in their first visit to a district title game since 1999.

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"Our lack of depth hurt us," Fulton added. "We play only six, maybe seven. We miss a lot when one of these kids goes down."

"We knew they didn't have a deep bench," Solon coach Julie Solis said. "But we are a team that always wants to get to the basket."

Yet the Comets didn't get to the rim much in the first half, hitting only five field goals out of 24 shots.

"We fiddled around with the ball too much in the first half," Solis said. "Part of that, I know, was their defense. In the second half we got much more off transition."

Speaking of defense, Olmsted Falls' leading scorer, Alexis Henton, was limited to five points as Dana Banda blanketed the Bulldogs star for the entire afternoon.

"They did a great job on Henton," Fulton said. "She couldn't get a shot off to save her life. Banda fought through every screen we tried to set for Alexis."

Henton hit the game's first basket, a 3-point goal, and made two free throws with four seconds to play.

Olmsted Falls was ahead for most of the first half, but relinquished the lead for good as Kristen Holmes, who scored 13 of her game-high 18 points in the second half, put in a basket 20 seconds into the third period. Jamie Glusling followed with a 3-pointer and the Comets kept increasing the lead from there.

Olmsted Falls hit only two of 10 field goal attempts in the third period and was 7-of-25 for the second half. The Bulldogs went 12-of-40 from the field for the game. Solon was 14-for-22 in the second half.

Ashley Hodge, despite being in foul trouble for most of the game, led the Bulldogs with 16 points and nine rebounds.

Contact Steve Byrne at 329-7135 or ctsports@chronicle.com.

Solon 52, Olmsted Falls 37

OLMSTED FALLS (37): Alexis Henton 1-0-5, Nicole Peterson 1-0-0, Dana Banda 2-0-0, Ashley Hodge 7-2-18, Brynna Roney 1-0-0. Totals 12-10-37.

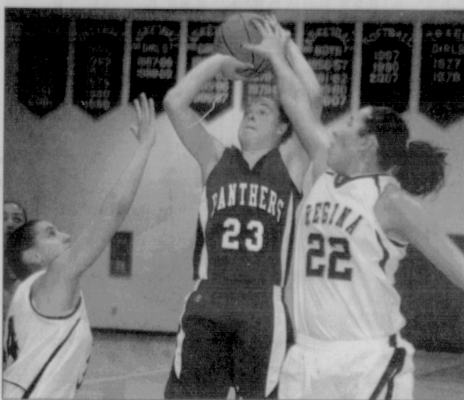
SOLON (52): Dana Banda 13-27, Dana Banda 2-0-0, Kristin Holmes 13-20, Melissa Thompson 4-11, Ashley Cumberlander 1-0-0, Emily Rosewater 0-0-0, Jamie Glusling 3-0-3, Dana Mitchell 0-0-0, Sara Ali 0-0-0, Aurora Ellis 0-0-0, Kristen Low 0-0-0, Taylor Henry 0-0-0. Totals 19-12-52.

Olmsted Falls 8 9 8 15 = 37

Solon 14 12 12 14 = 52

Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls 3 (Henton, Peterson, Roney); Solon 2 (Hodge, Glusling). Rebounds: Olmsted Falls 21 (Hodge 9, Solon 27 (Thompson). Fouls: Olmsted Falls 17, Solon 14. Total fouls: Olmsted Falls 21, Solon 15. Fouled out: Rosewater.

GIRLS BASKETBALL: DIVISION II DISTRICT



Elyria Catholic's Emily Taylor (23) tries to shoot past Regina's Amber Boyd, left, and Jackie Cook in a loss Saturday.

Not without a fight

Jim Jablonski
The Chronicle-Telegram

WELLINGTON — What do you do when you're in the district finals for the first time in years and your opponent has won 10 straight district titles? You can always keep your head up and forge straight ahead.

The Elyria Catholic Panthers did just that Saturday despite losing 72-38 to the Regina Royals, a powerful team that improved to 23-0 and will be making its 11th straight regional appearance. But Elyria still has a cloud over its head due to charges of subbing an illegal player in the first round of tournament play.

"I love these girls, they're great players and great people," said EC coach Eric Rothgery of his Panthers. "They weren't intimidated. We had a deal before the game — they don't look at the score, I handle that. They never quit and I can't ask for anything more."

"They were probably playing the best team in the state in any division with four Division I prospects. We were ready and focused and we got them back on their heels a few times and we're proud of that."

The tempo was set quickly as the Royals scored their first seven points before EC's Emily Taylor responded with a jump shot and 3-pointer a little past the midway point. The 7-5 difference was as close as it would be, as Regina's 6-foot-1 senior

Panthers battle,
but come up
short vs. Regina

Jackie Cook made three straight throws over a span of 1:24 for a 16-5 lead.

EC, whose tallest player is 5-10, had difficulty getting the ball inside against the Royals, who featured three regulars at 6-2, or taller. The result was a 26 percent field goal performance on 13-of-50 shooting. Meanwhile, Regina made 53 percent from the field on 26 of 49 shots.

Despite the wide margin, Regina coach Pat Dilulis did not let up on his team, expecting perfection at both ends of the floor.

"Sometimes they lose their focus," he said. "We have a high level of ability and we want to make sure we maximize that ability."

The Royals are still waiting to hear the outcome of the charges brought to the OHSAA regarding the illegal sub in their 80-16 victory over Brooklynn in the Wellington district opener Feb. 21. If they're forced to forfeit that game before any more games are played, EC would be the beneficiary and would advance to the regional.

Rothgery isn't counting on it. "You just never know," Rothgery said. "But we wouldn't practice unless we got a call (from the OHSAA). I would

have thought a decision would have been made already, but that's not our concern."

The Panthers hope out of the season with a district runner-up title and 16-8 record, big improvements over recent seasons. And they accomplished the turnaround with only one senior, Katherine McNeeley, who accepted the trophy for the team.

"We went into this game with our heads up," McNeeley said. "We're the type of team that never quits. This year has been awesome. I'm just happy that I stuck with the program when others quit. I've been very lucky to have the opportunity to play on such a good team my senior year. We can't hang our heads about anything."

Point guard Emily Taylor finished with 20 points to lead the Panthers.

Contact Jim Jablonski at 329-7135 or ctsports@chronicle.com.

Regina 72, EC 38

REGINA (72) Riley McCormick 3-0-4, Taylor Henry 4-0-13, Jackie Cook 4-1-5, Emily Taylor 10-20, Amber Boyd 3-4-12, Dana Mitchell 2-0-0, Jessica Ray 0-0-0, Patricia Hope 5-12, Surya Gaffney 0-0-0. Totals 26-50-72.

ELYRIA CATHOLIC (38) Emily Taylor 6-12, Emily Taylor 2-0-0, Katherine McNeeley 3-0-4, Katie Schumacher 1-0-0, Bridget Walsh 0-0-0, Natalie Wilkins 0-0-0, Daniela Lufano 0-0-0, Tony Rothgery 0-0-0, Juliana Tremont 0-0-0. Totals 13-50-38.

Regina 18 19 21 14 = 72
Elyria Catholic 11 12 6 = 38
Three-point goals: Regina 5-12 (Cook 3, Boyd 2, Gaffney 2-0-0, Taylor 2). Field goals: 50 (26 percent). Free throws: Regina 10-32 (40 percent). Elyria 10-32 (25 percent). Turnovers: Regina 12, Elyria 12. Rebounds: Regina 41, Elyria 20. Fouls: Regina 20, Elyria Catholic 25.

STATE GYMNASTICS

Dominant
performanceNortz wins
all-around,
3 event titlesBrian Dulik
The Chronicle-Telegram

HILLIARD — Bay Village resident Kelly Nortz left no doubt that she is the best high school gymnast in Ohio.

The Magnificent junior won the all-around championship, as well as event titles on the bars, floor and vault Saturday afternoon at the OHSA state individual meet.

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best. Her other winning scores were 9.425 (bars), 9.300 (vault) and 9.525 (floor).

The only other gymnast to take home a trophy was Columbus St. Francis de Sales' Gracey Brown (9.525) on the beam.

"I knew I had to come back and compete harder today because everybody was watching me," said Nortz, who was second in the 2008 all-around to former Magnificent teammate Kayla Knieck. "I expected myself to do it, so it wasn't a surprise, but it still feels great."

Cloverleaf freshman Ashley Rose (36.425) and junior Bridget Razem (36.375) were sixth and seventh, respectively, in the all-around. Blue Streaks freshman and Avon Lake resident Brianna Murnan (36.150) placed 10th and Olmsted Falls senior Katie Stallard (34.250) was 27th.

Stallard's top scores were a 9.100 on the floor and a 9.050 on the vault.

"It felt really good making it to state for the first time (as an individual) and being out there with all these great gymnasts," Stallard said. "It was so much fun having my best events also come in my favorite events."

In other event highlights, Magnificent freshman and Avon Lake resident Katie Cooney led for fifth on the beam (9.175) and Murnan tied for ninth on the floor (9.275). Rose was the runner-up on the bars (9.250).

"We're looking for three more good years from Brianna and Katie," Gura said. "With Kelly's leadership to build around, I think we have a good group for people to follow."

FALLS

From C1

Without him and because Falls came out red-hot, King fell behind by as many as 17 points in the first half.

"We dug a hole for ourselves in the first half," said Albert Sacey, King's coach. "Casey's a big player for us but what really took us out of the game was we really allowed (Olmsted Falls) to shoot some shots we didn't want them to. We really didn't play the defense that we wanted to play."

Olmsted Falls shot out to a 16-7 lead off a trio of long 3-pointers — one each from Colin Barth, Spencer Hawkins and Scott Kinney. Barth finished off the quarter with a 30-footer to beat the buzzer and give Falls a 23-12 lead, and the Bulldogs built the advantage to 40-23 off a steal and layup by Steve Battaglia.

"When we got up, I said they're too good a team," said Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue. "Al does a great job with those guys. They're very well-coached — that's what got them back in the game."

The Admirals did bounce back in the second half and took the lead, 67-65, once its full-court pressure started to make things happen. Bryant Parker's rebound basket and free throw tied it at 65 with just under six minutes to play, and Adrian Solis' steal and layup put King in front. But Falls refused to wilt under the pressure.

With the game tied at 74, Tony Lanza lobbed an inbounds pass to Kinney inside for a huge basket with 33

seconds left. Parker answered with a 3-pointer with 18 seconds left, but Hawkins made the play of his life as he grabbed a missed shot and somehow stuck it back in off the glass with 11 seconds to go. Kinney then tied it with a steal and throw-down as the clock expired.

"I knew they were going to get Malcolm (Barnett) the ball," said Kinney, who led Falls with 26 points. "He was lighting it up all game. He's a heck of a player. I just tried to keep the passing lane. Good thing it worked out."

"There's no drill for that," Hawkins said of his clutch rebound basket. "I just tried to stay focused and tried to put it in. It went down."

"It came down to two plays at the end," said Sacey. "Olmsted Falls made the plays at the end to win the ballgame and we didn't."

Casey finished with just two points and five rebounds, but Barnett came through with 23 points. Bryant Parker added 13 points and Vincent Lee 10 to go along with five steals. For Falls, Barth finished with 20 points and seven assists. Hawkins had 16 points.

O. Falls 80, A. King 77

ADMIRAL KING (77) Bryant Parker 4-4-13, Vincent Lee 4-2-10, Malcolm Barnett 7-6-20, Adrian Harris 1-2-4, Adrian Casey 1-0-2, AJ Johnson 2-0-4, Gary Donald 0-2-14, Adrian Sacey 2-7, Jordan Casey 0-0-0.

OLMSTED FALLS (80) Scott Kinney 10-4-21, John Adams 0-0-0, Spencer Hawkins 5-0-16, Steve Battaglia 3-0-4, Colin Barth 6-4-20, Tony Lanza 3-0-4, Ian Sparks 0-0-0, Orlando Glenn 0-0-0, Brandon Riles 0-0-0, Cory Mendicino 0-0-0, Brenten Lant 0-0-0. Totals 27-15-80.

Admiral King 15 17 21 24 = 77

Olmsted Falls 22 22 16 19 = 80

Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls 11-19 (Barth 4, Hawkins 3, Kinney 2, Lanza 2, Field Goaler Anthony Smith 2). Field goals: 27 (44.4 percent). Free throws: Admiral King 15-25 (60 percent). Olmsted Falls 27-44 (61 percent). Fouls: Olmsted Falls 19-25 (68 percent). Rebounds: Admiral King 25 (Glenn, Harris, Donald 5, Olmsted Falls 34 (Kinney 9).

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